

IN CONTEXT

Verismo

Verismo (realism) is a term for the dominant style in Italian opera in the 1890s. Puccini's *Tosca* was heavily influenced by verismo, as were, to a lesser extent, his *Madama Butterfly* and *La fanciulla del West*. The genre was founded by Pietro Mascagni's *Cavalleria rusticana* (1890) and Ruggero Leoncavallo's *Pagliacci* (1892), two short operas often performed as a double-bill. The verismo composers presented dramas that were raw, brutal, and even sordid. They required singers to adopt an emotional, declamatory style that sacrificed beauty to power of expression.



SCENE FROM CAVALLERIA RUSTICANA BY
PIETRO MASCAGNI

Born in the historic Tuscan town of Lucca in 1858, Giacomo Puccini was the oldest son of a family of nine. The male line in